ing Covid-appropriate behaviour to contain the pandemic. Unlike a year ago when some patients had to wait an average of five days for a test report in NCR (National Capital Region), today one can acquire test results with a home antigen kit in less than five minutes. Available for as little as Rs 140 on e-commerce sites, such kits have become extremely popular. "Most of my patients have been taking the home tests," says Pune-based general physician Dr Ravindra Naik.

The country's treatment arsenal is also considerably fortified. During the third wave, doctors had to edge out monoclonal antibody treatments, which had been very effective against the Delta variant but were far less so for Omicron, the dominant variant in the wave. As Dr Nangia says, "Emerging evidence showed that the treatment was not effective and we reduced our use significantly." This had for the past few months worried those who remained vulnerable to Omicron—the elderly and those with comorbid conditions. Till a new antiviral drug, which goes by the generic name of Paxlovid and comes from pharma major Pfizer, extended renewed hope. Especially as doctors say that Omicron and its subvariants—BA.1, BA.2 and XE—have evolved to escape previous immunity. Paxlovid has proved to be 89 per cent effective in reducing the risk of hospitalisation and death among the vulnerable, more than some of the current vaccines in the market. "It is meant for those who are at high risk, and displaying mild to moderate symptoms. The efficacy is quite good against Omicron and, if prescribed by a doctor, it should be taken without any delay," says Delhi-based infectious diseases specialist Dr Ankita Baidya.

The Hyderabad-based Hetero pharma company already has DCGI (Drug Controller General of India) approval to launch Paxlovid. Sources believe the drug will be available in the market in the first week of May itself. This prescription oral treatment is made up of nirmatrelvir, which stops the virus from replicating, and ritonavir, which slows down nirmatrelvir's breakdown so that it stays in the body longer in high concentration. Paxlovid is administered as three tablets (two of nirmatrelvir and one of ritonavir) taken together orally twice daily for five days after symptoms start. The drug has already received emergency-use approval in the US and UK, and is 'strongly recommended' by the World Health Organization for non-severe Covid patients at the highest risk of hospitalisation. The price of the drug in India is yet to be disclosed.

A few months ago, the country had seen the introduction of another promising pill—Merck's molnupiravir. However, fear that the pill could insert errors in the DNA of a developing foetus, sperm cells or children meant the medication was never formally integrated into the country's

WHAT TO WATCH OUT FOR NOW

- **A recombinant strain is not unusual:** Viruses evolve in order to overcome the defences of a body. If a person gets infected by two strains, a third strain, such as XE, can emerge
- **Reinfection can happen:** The XE variant has mutations that help it overcome previously-acquired immunity. And so individuals can get Covid again, including those vaccinated. However, vaccines help prevent hospitalisation and death
- **Symptoms are mild, but Long Covid remains a concern:** Fever, body ache and mild upper respiratory infection are the common symptoms of XE so far, but its long-term impact remains unknown. Reports include anxiety, allergies, persisting weakness, hormonal changes, hair fall and lasting bodyache
- **Children not at greater risk so far:** Even though they haven't been vaccinated, so far there hasn't been a significant rise in the severity of the disease in children

PAXLOVID, PFIZER'S NEW DRUG

--It is an antiviral drug that is being manufactured by the Hyderabad-based Hetero pharma group for the Indian market

--Studies have shown it to be 89% effective in preventing hospitalisation and death. It is FDA-approved and strongly recommended by WHO.

--If prescribed by a doctor, it needs to be taken within five days from the onset of symptoms. The tablet has to be given in three doses (two tablets of nirmatrelvir and one of ritonavir) taken together, twice daily for five days

--It is made up of nirmatrelvir, which stops the virus from replicating, and ritonavir, which slows down nirmatrelvir's breakdown so that the drug stays in the body for a longer time in high concentration